

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

Instead of 'Don't Cry': 20 Phrases

Emotion coaching scripts · Ages 2–4

When a child cries, our instinct is to make it stop. But the fastest way through a big feeling is to feel understood. These phrases help.

What the research found

- Parents who use emotion coaching (noticing, naming and accepting emotions) have children with better emotional regulation (Gottman, 1997).
- A parenting programme teaching emotion coaching reduced children's behaviour problems (Havighurst et al., 2010).

Name the feeling

- “You're sad the park time is over.”
- “You're so frustrated the tower fell.”
- “You're disappointed it's not the blue cup.”
- “That scared you.”

Accept it

- “It's okay to cry.”
- “I'm here. Take your time.”
- “That was really hard.”
- “I'd feel sad too.”

Set a limit on actions (not feelings)

- ○ “You can be angry. I won't let you hit.”
- ○ “You can cry. Throwing isn't okay.”
- ○ “You can stamp your feet instead.”

After the storm

- ○ “You felt really sad, and now you feel better.”
- ○ “What could we do next time?”
- ○ A hug, a drink of water, back to play.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Gottman, J. (1997). Raising an Emotionally Intelligent Child. Simon & Schuster.
Havighurst, S. S., et al. (2010). Tuning in to Kids: Improving emotion socialization practices in parents of preschool children. Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry, 51(12), 1342–1350.

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